

Ranked
10

T. Mitra
26, Thiruvananthapuram

Orphaned just four days before the UPSC exam, she was ranked tenth in her second attempt

Living her Dream

Ranked 10th in this year's civil services exams, T. Mitra hasn't stopped crying since the day she heard the news. The result came just four days after the death of her father Thrivikraman Nair, whose sole ambition was to see his daughter become an IAS officer. Her mother had died a year ago when Mitra was busy preparing for her preliminary exams. Currently living with her lecturer sister, Mitra rues that neither of her parents could live to see their dream come true. "My involvement in the preparation helped me get over the grief," says the post-graduate in English

Literature, who cleared the exam in her second attempt. It was her father who was her guiding light. "I didn't have enough time to read all newspapers and magazines every day. So he used to clip important news items and file them," she says, her face lost in memory. An addict of English fiction, Mitra is doing a PhD in Cultural Pluralism in the Fiction of Hanif Kureishi and Sally Smith. She loves re-reading *A Fine Balance* by her favourite author Rohinton Mistry. A Hindi film music buff and a "group singer", her favourite crooner is "Alka Yagnik, without doubt."

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

"Students had begun to prefer corporate jobs to civil services. The pendulum is swinging the other way now."



C. SHANKAR



SANJAY KUMAR

Ranked
4

Varinder Kumar Sharma, 35, Patiala

Polio couldn't stop him, nor could his decision to take the exam in Punjabi. The first among men is a very special achiever.

Equal to the Challenge

Varinder Kumar Sharma, who stood first among male candidates and fourth overall, believes in thinking positive. Afflicted with polio, he calls it a "blessing in disguise as it gave me a chance to appear in the UPSC exam even at 35". (The government introduced three per cent reservation for the disabled in 2003.) A PCS (Allied) officer, Sharma comes from a family of teachers. His wife too teaches Punjabi. "This was one reason why I opted for the language as a medium and for Punjabi literature as one of the optionals despite initial discouragement from well-meaning friends. I can express myself freely in it."

Sharma was educated in schools in Patiala before moving to the S.A. Jain Atma Ram College in Ambala. He got a degree in electrical engineering from Chandigarh's Punjab Engineering College and became a subdivisional officer. In 2003, he was selected for the PCS Allied Services. Unlike most of the other successful candidates, Sharma didn't go to Delhi for coaching. Though posted in Ludhiana, he sought a transfer to Chandigarh where he could prepare better. "It wasn't easy to stay away from my wife and two daughters who have been in Sangrur now for a full year," he says. He opted for a retired Punjabi professor as his coach on the subject and attended a professional coaching centre for sociology. In retrospect, it was worth it.

by Arvind Chhabra

"I opted for Punjabi literature because my wife teaches it. She was a great support."